

Tig said this option is useful if I just want the money for immediate use, but less so if I want to save up for something special, like for a gadget. (I see what Tig is into. It's gadgets.)

After my lovely experience at Bank of America, it was hard to swallow the notion that banks are evil empires that control our economy. But the more I was learning, the more that seemed to be the case.

Lisa Servon, author of the book *The Unbanking of America*, which explains why we rely so heavily on banks, says that many people don't have enough money to keep a minimum balance or wait for a check to clear into a bank account. It doesn't help that the minimum balance for free checking is constantly rising; in some cases, it's a few thousand dollars. "More than half of all Americans could not come up with \$2,000 in the event of an emergency," she said. If their balance drops below the minimum, they're paying overdraft fees for banking. (PAYING. TO KEEP. YOUR MONEY. IN A BANK. Ugh.) Many low-income people use only cash for these reasons, but there are many vendors out there who don't even take cash or take it only if you spend a certain amount.

Lisa's examples are just some of the practices designed by banks to make money off their customers. Another one is debit resequencing, and it goes like this. You have \$100 in your bank account. On Monday morning, the auto-pay you have set up for your phone bill for \$75 kicks in. You then go to the grocery store and buy \$125 worth of groceries. You also write a check to your landlord for \$500. All those charges hit at the same time. What does the bank do? It *could* register the \$75 charge first because that would clear. You would then pay two overdraft fees for the other two charges, which would overdraw your checking account.

BUT THAT'S NOT WHAT HAPPENS. Instead, banks use a software program that reorders those charges to put the highest one first. The \$500 landlord check hits your account first, making it *three* overdraft fees instead of two. You're fucked.

Nicole Aschoff of *Jacobin* magazine said banks were not always out to get the customer. In the 1970s and 1980s, the US government bent to pressure to deregulate the financial sector. The banks wanted more opportunities to make money and convinced the government this would fix the stagnation of the